

LA BELLE EPOQUE AND THE JAZZ AGE

Simplification and in particular the idea that "less is more" governed the development of fashion in the early 20th century. The old way of dressing was only abandoned after a final extravagant flourish, which found shape in Paul Poiret's colourful Orientalist designs and Lucile's gossamer creations. The beginning of World War I accelerated the trend towards less restrictive clothing, as many women became used to wearing practical uniforms. After the War the popularity of elaborate hairpieces and many layers of flimsy fabric diminished in favour of practical, shorter skirts and sweaters. The figure of the static, hourglass woman was being replaced by the energetic, boyish "flapper". Always on the move – either dancing the night away or racing around in an automobile – the new style represented youth, fashion, and fun.

The suntan era

Men and women increasingly revealed their bodies, as clothes shrank and became less structured. The fashionable set went to Malibu and Palm Beach in the US, or the Riviera in France, to acquire a suntan and to flaunt their beach pyjamas and summer suits. Different outerwear also meant changes to previously restrictive undergarments – fewer pieces of less-rigid underwear became possible. New designers were particularly adept at picking up the trend towards increased movement and practicality in fashion. French designers Chanel and Patou both started their Houses just before World War I, and promoted clothes for the active woman, in which knitwear featured prominently.

New icons

Royalty and aristocracy still played a significant role in setting trends. In Britain, Prince Edward initiated and popularized new styles. Following his investiture as Prince of Wales in 1910, the 16-year-old heir to the throne soon became a major fashion icon, accelerating the move towards less structured garments. He also popularized the use of garments such as Fair Isle knitted vests and plus fours off the golf course. With the rise of Hollywood during the second decade of the century, film stars such as Douglas Fairbanks, Rudolph Valentino, and Louise Brooks began to supplant high-society figures in setting trends.



1901–03	1904–07	1908–10	
1902 J.C. Penney, the American retail magnate, opens his first department store in Wyoming, USA.		1908 Mannequin parades are introduced at the House of Lucile in London, and become very popular.	
c.1903 The straight-fronted corset, also known as the swan-bill, S-bend, or "health corset", is popular from the turn of the century until the 1910s. It forces the torso forward and makes the hips protrude, removing pressure from the abdomen and creating an S-shaped silhouette.		1909 Bobbed or short hair for women is introduced to Paris fashion.	
	1905 Artificial silk made from viscose (known as "rayon" after 1924) is first sold commercially in the UK. It reaches the US in 1910.	1910 Mariano Fortuny patents his pleating and dyeing process. His long, clinging sheath dresses, known as Delphos, are made with a single, vibrantly coloured piece of silk. Devotees include stars such as Eleanora Duse, Isadora Duncan, Cleo de Merode, and Liane de Pougy.	
	1906 Madame Paquin introduces the empire-waist dress in imitation of the fashion of the Regency period.	1910 Paul Poiret designs a range of loose-fitting, Oriental-inspired dresses, paving the way for modern dress. ▼ A Paul Poiret creation designed for a fancy dress party	